
A: We have come a long way since we started our digital transformation. When GPT (generative pre-trained transformers, or a family of large language models) was commercialised, our team moved quickly. We created our own GPT, available to every employee, who can operate through a mobile app.

We use AI in multiple ways. We use it to build our smart factories. We have automated these sites to make them much more efficient, bring products faster to market and increase quality and reliability of manufacturing operations. AI comes into play in many of our HR processes to make the right decisions on people with the right level of information. Plus, it is also used to make our research and development (R&D) more productive based on data.

We have a framework for AI to create additional growth, generate innovation, and make us work more efficiently. We use it for customer insights, to get sharper with our marketing strategy, and understand customer expectations.

I look at AI as a revolution. I have spent a lot of time training myself in AI.

Q: Does that mean Merck is thinking like a technology company?

14 | A: We are a global science and tech company. Both are interrelated and, at this point, technology is being powered by science. When I say we are using AI to improve drug discovery, that is about science and tech. That means both have converged quickly. We also use AI to predict the success of some clinical trials. I believe the revolution is already underway.

Equally, we need to be aware of the potential risks. Obviously, like other companies, there is cyber security risk. We must be mindful of how to use AI to benefit us as a company. Besides, there is a need to protect our systems to minimise liabilities towards employees, the company and our customers.

Q: Given your presence in electronics, does it help in understanding the AI story better?

“We have the talent and capabilities to manufacture for our operations globally and through our IT centre in India, which provides data and automation capabilities”

